

Chapter 69-1

This was an extremely restrained touch.

The lips were ice-cold, yet they warmed the instant they pressed down.

The black umbrella appeared solemn and dignified in the cemetery. Liang Shi's eyes were instantly shrouded and invaded by darkness, the umbrella top pressing against the crown of her head. The hand gripping the umbrella handle tightened, her fair hand immediately tensing, her body stiffening.

But her emotions grew infinitely heavy with the rain, becoming low along with Xu Qingzhu's emotions.

The sound of rain and footsteps overlapped.

Unhurried footsteps passed by their sides, the large umbrella enveloping both of them.

No one could see their faces clearly.

Liang Shi's fingertips gently landed at the corner of Xu Qingzhu's eye, wiping away that tear that had been condensed by the cold air.

The hand holding the umbrella was grasped by Xu Qingzhu, but her hand was too cold.

Liang Shi turned her own hand over, covering the back of her hand, trying to pass her a trace of warmth.

At the same time, in this bitter cold wind, she closed her eyes, her other hand falling on the back of Xu Qingzhu's head, gently stroking the crown of her head.

Fine threads of rain entwined in the wind, condensing into water droplets along the direction of the umbrella ribs.

Patter—

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Xu Qingzhu retreated when she was just one step away from the truth. Liang Shi shielded her from all the slanting wind and cold rain.

In that moment, Liang Shi thought, this mission could be left undone.

Not because she felt it couldn't be completed, but purely out of protecting Xu Qingzhu's tottering faith.

Standing outside the door of truth, Xu Qingzhu was fragile and distant, like a breakable porcelain doll.

So Liang Shi chose to accompany her in burying those truths together.

Their current life was the truth.

There was no deeper meaning.

Until the footsteps disappeared, Xu Qingzhu slowly opened her eyes. In the dimness, she and Liang Shi looked at each other.

She lightly licked her lips, the corners of her mouth turning up, but in her eyes was a bottomless sadness.

Liang Shi's hand gently patted the crown of her head, lowering her voice to coax softly: "You stand here, and I'll go pick up the bracelet for you, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't speak.

Liang Shi released the hand holding hers, then bent down and emerged from under the umbrella.

The rain fell on her clothes and the tips of her hair, but she didn't feel cold. The large black umbrella enveloped the thin Xu Qingzhu within it, as if isolating a cold little world.

Liang Shi worried about Xu Qingzhu's emotions, and even called out to her in the rain: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu let out a muffled single syllable: "Mm?"

Liang Shi's ears were filled with the sound of wind and rain—she couldn't hear at all—but as she walked forward, she said: "Stand still and don't move. Wait for me."

Xu Qingzhu stood lonely under the black umbrella. She also wore all black, blending into this lonely and solemn cemetery.

Her entire being was lifeless.

She lowered her eyelids, lightly pressing her lips together, watching the lines of rain meandering down the gray stone slabs.

Xu Qingzhu's body trembled uncontrollably. In her mind, it was as if countless threads were growing in a tangled mess, unbridled, heading toward deeper places.

It seemed like a bottomless abyss—once fallen in, there would be no redemption.

She wanted to close her eyes, but it was as if someone was forcefully compelling her to keep them open.

The string in her brain called reason was pulled tighter and tighter. Since the last relapse at the hospital, she hadn't experienced this similar emotion again.

It felt like she could barely hold on anymore.

.....

Xu Qingzhu's breathing became tense, and she couldn't grip the umbrella tightly. The umbrella tilted from her shoulder, half her body exposed to the rain.

Her hands completely lost their strength, and the umbrella fell to the ground, rolling two circles before stopping.

Just as the string in her mind was about to snap, Liang Shi ran over quickly and hugged her tightly.

Liang Shi held her entire person in her embrace, saying in a low voice: "Xu Qingzhu, it's okay."

Her gentle voice fell into Xu Qingzhu's ears, "I'm here."

Memory seemed to return to many years ago, when that gentle older sister¹ said to her: "It's alright, don't be afraid."

Footnotes:

¹ 姐姐 (jiějie) - Older sister: A term that can refer to one's biological older sister, but is also commonly used in Chinese culture to address any older female figure with affection and respect. In this context, it refers to a significant person from Xu Qingzhu's past who played a protective, caring role in her life.

Chapter 69-2

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Hospital.

Zhao Xuning walked out of the ward, and Liang Shi immediately stepped forward, asking nervously: "Is she alright?"

"Nothing serious." Zhao Xuning removed her stethoscope. "She fainted due to excessive nervousness. She'll be fine after some rest."

The weight that had been hanging in Liang Shi's heart finally settled.

"So, what happened?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "Sorry, it involves privacy, so I won't say."

Zhao Xuning didn't continue asking, but went downstairs with her to have a cup of coffee together.

The rain in the city had stopped long ago, and pedestrians on the road remained hurried.

This city was still in the midst of its busyness.

Liang Shi had been caught in the rain, and her clothes were somewhat wet, so she simply took off her coat and draped it over her arm.

The wind was strong, and when it blew on her body, the damp clothes stuck to her, making her particularly uncomfortable.

But Liang Shi was preoccupied and didn't go buy new clothes.

It was only after returning to the hospital that Zhao Xuning gave her one of her own coats to change into.

Zhao Xuning had a shift change after three o'clock. After the handover ended, she came over to check again, instructing Liang Shi to take good care of Xu Qingzhu. She told her to remember to call her back when Xu Qingzhu woke up, then left the hospital.

After that, Liang Shi stayed in the ward the entire time, all the way until evening.

After the heavy rain, the sky produced a brilliant red sunset glow that dyed the distant dark horizon red. Even the color reflected on the glass was rendered in red.

It looked like tomorrow should be good weather.

Liang Shi dozed off in the quiet ward.

Perhaps it was because the emotions during the day were too oppressive—in a trance, she actually dreamed of the abandoned factory.

In the abandoned factory, dark as if there were no sun or sky, smoke swirled around. A group of people spoke in dialects she couldn't understand, and there were two spirited, large yellow dogs¹.

This place seemed to be holding many children, but she couldn't see very clearly.

She lay on the cold cement floor, as if she could die at any moment.

Someone called out to her in a low voice: "Elder sister—"

Then that scene was as if someone had splashed blood on it—countless red marks shattered the image.

That originally cautious voice became filled with a sense of brokenness, as if it were a desperate cry—

"Bang."

Pain came from her forehead, the feeling of weightlessness disappeared, but Liang Shi only opened her eyes slightly, then exhaled.

This dream had no beginning or end, but it was frightening.

She didn't know who was calling her for help.

Or perhaps it was simply stress.

Liang Shi adjusted her breathing several times, reaching up to rub her forehead. After a while, she slowly opened her eyes.

She hardly needed to adjust—outside was already completely dark. Except for the weak light from the street lamps shining in, there was no other light source in the entire ward.

The disinfectant smell unique to hospital rooms made Liang Shi a bit uncomfortable. She rubbed her nose, then used the weak light to go to the door to turn on the lights.

In an instant, light fell into the room, and she looked toward Xu Qingzhu lying on the hospital bed.

The other person squinted her eyes.

Xu Qingzhu let out a light breath, then raised the back of her hand to shield her eyes. Her cool voice carried a bit of hoarseness: "How long did I sleep?"

"Half a day." Liang Shi answered, then asked: "Are you hungry?"

Xu Qingzhu sat up and looked at the needle mark on the back of her hand. After being pricked with a needle, the fair back of her hand always left behind bruises. She frowned slightly, only asking in a low voice: "Can I be discharged?"

"Sure, Zhao Xuning said you simply didn't sleep enough." Liang Shi told a white lie, keeping quiet about the morning incident at the cemetery, and even teased: "Teacher Xu, no matter how busy you are with work, you still need to take care of your health? Staying up late on your day off—do you not value your life?"

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head back slightly. From Liang Shi's angle, she could just see her slender swan neck²—her milky white skin made her entire person seem to glow.

In Liang Shi's mind, countless thoughts had already flashed by: Too thin! Take her to eat something delicious!

At this moment, she looked cold and distant, with a somewhat fragile quality.

Liang Shi also controlled the degree of her joking extremely well, her tone very light, her intonation rising slightly, wanting to bring her a bit of liveliness.

Clearly, after she finished speaking, Xu Qingzhu was slightly stunned, thinking that Liang Shi would ask her about the morning's events.

But Liang Shi didn't mention it at all, only joking with her as usual.

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's lips curved up, bringing up a faint arc. Her clear eyes also curved slightly, her eyes seemingly filled with starlight.

She turned to the side to look toward Liang Shi, meeting Liang Shi's gaze, responding with the same teasing tone as in Liang Shi's words: "No choice, I have to work to support the family."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow: "So Teacher Xu means I can't provide for us?"

"Well, two people's strength is always greater than one person's, right?" Xu Qingzhu's long hair was scattered over her shoulders. On her delicate collarbone, she wore a silver necklace. Her face still had the pallor from not recovering after excessive emotional tension, her lips without much color. But those eyes, when they hooked upward, just happened to grasp the perfect degree of charm.

Cold and beautiful, yet not lacking in allure.

Her long and upturned eyelashes added a touch of cuteness to her eyes, but her entire face was cold.

Yet the moment the corners of her mouth curved up, it could make all things in the world pale in comparison.

Liang Shi was momentarily stunned.

Footnotes:

¹ Large yellow dogs (大黄狗) - A common breed of dog in China, typically tan/yellow in color, often used as guard dogs in rural areas.

² Swan neck - A Chinese expression used to describe an elegant, slender neck, considered a mark of beauty and grace.

Chapter 69-3

Xu Qingzhu leaned back against the pillow, casually tilting her head back, her entire person appearing languid yet charming.

A moment later, Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Teacher Liang, what are you thinking about?"

The suddenly ringing voice finally pulled Liang Shi's wandering thoughts back. She immediately lowered her head: "Nothing."

—How could she be so rude as to stare at someone?

—Without even thinking, she knew her expression just now must have looked very foolish.

—But Xu Qingzhu was truly beautiful, like someone who had walked out of a painting, both lively and ethereal.

Liang Shi's mind was filled with random thoughts, finally attributing this inexplicable loss of composure to—Xu Qingzhu being too beautiful.

Truly worthy of being the novel's female lead!

"What do you want to eat?" Liang Shi, afraid of being teased by Xu Qingzhu about this matter, immediately started a new topic.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment: "How about the snack street?"

Liang Shi: "!"

Liang Shi had only seen the so-called "snack street" during filming.

Every city has a "snack street," which can be large or small. Some are a city's food collection, some are "food anthologies" from various places.

The slightly better-developed ones would become a city's check-in spot¹.

Dozens of roadside stalls set up together, with all sorts of fragrances floating in the air.

The street lights were bright, but they seemed less bright when they fell on the stalls. Each stall would have its own lights.

An entire street was an extremely lively place filled with the aroma of everyday life².

The original host probably had never been there even once.

Liang Shi was also quite surprised that Xu Qingzhu even knew about such a place.

After all, these were "slum delicacies³."

And after getting in the car, Xu Qingzhu directly told the navigation the destination—Qingyi University's South Gate Two.

Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat. Although her emotions were still slightly low, they weren't as gloomy as when she had just woken up.

After the car had driven for a stretch, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Teacher Liang, thank you."

Liang Shi was confused: "For what?"

"I don't know." Xu Qingzhu said: "Anyway, thank you."

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

"So as thanks, tonight I'm treating you to the super invincible devil spicy set meal at our school's entrance." Xu Qingzhu said: "I dare say, in all of Haizhou City, there isn't a single shop whose hot and sour noodles⁴ can compare to the spiciness of theirs."

Liang Shi: "?"

She was shocked, yet also very considerately answered: "Okay."

"There's also takoyaki⁵ and beef buns." Xu Qingzhu said: "If you have a big appetite, I can also treat you to fried chicken."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi couldn't help but glance at Xu Qingzhu with her peripheral vision. She saw that when she spoke about these dishes, there were stars in her eyes.

It was an expression of great anticipation.

Suddenly, for that one instant, she no longer felt that Xu Qingzhu was an unattainable fairy.

It was as if she were simply the girl next door, or a cute junior from school, introducing her favorite foods to her like precious treasures.

"Your school? It's also Sally and Lin Luoxi's school, right?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded, then touched her phone screen and suddenly asked: "Do you mind eating together?"

"Eating what?" Liang Shi asked.

"Dinner." Xu Qingzhu had already unlocked her screen. "I'll call Sally and Cherry over, and we can eat dinner together."

Liang Shi nodded: "I don't mind."

With more people, it would be livelier. Once it became lively, the sadness would be diluted.

Liang Shi naturally wouldn't mind.

¹ Check-in spot (打卡地) - A popular term in Chinese social media culture referring to trendy locations where people go to take photos and "check in" on social media platforms.

² Aroma of everyday life (煙火氣) - Literally "smoke and fire energy," this Chinese expression refers to the warm, bustling atmosphere of everyday life, particularly associated with cooking, eating, and the vibrancy of common people's lives. It conveys a sense of down-to-earth authenticity and human warmth.

³ Slum delicacies (貧民窟美食) - A somewhat humorous/ironic term referring to inexpensive street food or hole-in-the-wall eateries that are delicious but not fancy or expensive, implying these are foods the wealthy elite might look down upon.

⁴ Hot and sour noodles (酸辣粉) - A popular Sichuan street food consisting of sweet potato noodles in a spicy and tangy broth, typically garnished with peanuts, preserved vegetables, and chili oil.

⁵ Takoyaki (章魚小丸子) - Literally "octopus little balls," a popular Japanese street food that has become widespread in China, consisting of ball-shaped snacks made of wheat flour batter filled with pieces of octopus.

Chapter 69-4

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Since it was Sunday, when Liang Shi drove the car to South Gate Two, she couldn't find a parking spot at all, so she drove the car to a place far away, parked it properly, then walked back from there.

The wind was strong at night. Liang Shi put her already-dried coat on Xu Qingzhu.

An Alpha's build was slightly larger, so the clothes were correspondingly bigger as well.

Xu Qingzhu wore it like an oversized garment, folding the sleeves up one layer.

They had just arrived not long ago when Sally and Lin Luoxi also came.

Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "Why are you two together?"

Sally answered: "We were playing cards together."

But Lin Luoxi looked listless, glancing at Sally sideways, yet unusually didn't retort at her.

"What's wrong?" Xu Qingzhu asked in a low voice: "Did you lose money?"

"Mm." Lin Luoxi responded weakly: "Lost over ten thousand."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"Playing that big?" Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue. "Who were you two playing with?"

"With two of our friends." Lin Luoxi stared at Sally's back, pressing her temples¹, her body also unable to hold up. She hooked her arm around Xu Qingzhu's, resting her head on Xu Qingzhu's shoulder. Since the two had similar heights, this posture was a bit awkward for her, but ultimately her body won out. She asked with particular incomprehension: "Why do some people, after all these years, still act like dogs²?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't understand: "What do you mean?"

Lin Luoxi glanced at her, then said in a low voice: "After doing it, she still had to drag me to play cards for a whole day. I don't understand."

Xu Qingzhu: "???"

Her pupils震惊³, "Doing it? Is it the 'doing it' I understand?"

"What else?" Lin Luoxi took a step up, her legs trembling weakly. But she was leaning on Xu Qingzhu, and Xu Qingzhu almost tripped as well. Fortunately, Liang Shi reached out to support her in time, then said helplessly: "Cherry, how about I help you instead?"

"Don't." Lin Luoxi sighed. "I don't want to have unclear relationships with my bestie's wife."

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Actually, for this kind of thing, I don't mind."

"I mind." Lin Luoxi said, straightening her body. "Playing cards for a whole day, my waist is about to break."

"Sally." Liang Shi called out to Sally who had been leading the way at the front. "Come over and help Cherry."

Sally immediately jogged over: "I thought she was going to cling to Blanche and not let go."

"You won, so you're afraid I'll hit you, right?" Lin Luoxi said through gritted teeth, then pinched Sally's arm. Sally sucked in a breath of cold air: "OMG, Blanche, save me!"

Xu Qingzhu stood to the side and shook her head: "I can't help you."

Liang Shi immediately pulled Xu Qingzhu to her side: "Don't involve innocent people in your couple's affairs."

Sally & Lin Luoxi: "....."

Both their expressions froze. Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "You two haven't made up yet?"

Lin Luoxi cleared her throat: "Currently not a couple yet."

Sally looked aggrieved on the side: "She won't agree to be with me."

Lin Luoxi couldn't help it and pinched her again: "Why won't I agree? Don't you have any idea?"

So the two started arguing again.

But this argument ended very quickly.

Liang Shi hadn't been to this place before, but the three of them were regulars.

Entering the hot and sour noodle shop that Xu Qingzhu mentioned, it was practically packed with people.

"After all these years, this shop is still so popular." Lin Luoxi said: "I haven't been here in so long."

Sally interjected from the side: "I came twice after returning to the country. I asked you to come that day, but you wouldn't."

"I haven't been here since graduating." Xu Qingzhu said.

This resulted in Sally and Lin Luoxi asking in unison: "How long ago did you graduate?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Not long ago."

The shop was lively, and their chatting back and forth was also lively. Liang Shi simply acted as a background character.

The legendarily devil-spicy hot and sour noodles made Liang Shi's eyes turn red from the first bite. She drank many mouthfuls of water but still couldn't suppress it.

Yet it was quite fragrant, making one want to try a second bite.

Xu Qingzhu wasn't particularly good at eating spicy food either, but here, she stubbornly finished an entire bowl. It made her forehead break out in a layer of sweat and also made her eyes red. Her lip color became even more vivid than if she'd applied lipstick.

Afterward, they went to browse the entire snack street. Whenever they encountered something particularly delicious, Xu Qingzhu would stop to buy it.

In the end, they bought a whole bunch of things, but with many people, they divided it up quickly and didn't have much left.

Liang Shi ate quite full though.

After parting ways with Sally and the others, Liang Shi drove back to Qianshuiwan⁴. When passing by the central square, there was a building that was built very beautifully.

Light strips were wound around the rooftop, looking reassuring.

Liang Shi didn't see it—it was Xu Qingzhu sitting in the passenger seat who said: "Look at that building."

Liang Shi glanced over while waiting at a red light, then silently memorized the name of the residential complex.

Before bed, Liang Shi brought a cup of milk upstairs for Xu Qingzhu. Xu Qingzhu was sitting on the edge of the bed, not knowing what she was thinking about.

Liang Shi pushed open the door to see her tilting her head back slightly, her expression wooden.

Liang Shi placed the milk on the bedside table, instructing in a low voice: "Drink it and then rest early."

"I already slept all afternoon." Xu Qingzhu said: "Not very sleepy."

"You can read for a while." Liang Shi said: "Don't always think about random things."

"I'm not thinking about anything." Xu Qingzhu answered reflexively.

After answering, she fell silent again. When Liang Shi was about to say something, Xu Qingzhu had already changed the topic: "Liang Shi, let's go to the nursing home tomorrow afternoon."

"Huh?" Liang Shi was surprised: "You're not going to work?"

"I'll finish what needs to be done tomorrow morning, and we'll go around four in the afternoon." Xu Qingzhu said: "Going on a weekday should be better. Ask your supervisor for leave."

"Okay." Liang Shi agreed.

Liang Shi only told her to rest well, but after walking out of the room, she couldn't help but turn back, pushing open the door to say to her: "Teacher Xu."

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice rose slightly: "Mm?"

"Yaya called me at noon and asked us to come back for dinner." Liang Shi said: "I put her off, and then she asked us to come home next week."

"Alright."

"You see." Liang Shi smiled. "You're being loved by so many people."

Footnotes:

¹ Pressing temples (摁太陽穴) - A common Chinese gesture when one has a headache or is feeling stressed/tired, where one presses the temple area with fingers.

² Act like dogs (還是狗) - Chinese slang meaning someone is behaving badly, unreliably, or being a "dog" (derogatory), often used playfully among close friends to mean someone is being inconsiderate or annoying.

³ 瞳孔地震 - Literally "pupil earthquake," an internet slang expression meaning to be shocked or have one's mind blown, often used humorously to describe extreme surprise.

⁴ Qianshuiwan (淺水灣) - Literally "Shallow Water Bay," the name of the residential area where the characters live.

Chapter 69-5

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Xu Qingzhu was quite deeply touched by Liang Shi's words.

The train of thought that had already entered a dead end seemed to suddenly open up in that instant, then she let this matter pass.

Early the next morning, Xu Qingzhu deliberately set an earlier alarm, planning to make breakfast after getting up. But when she came downstairs, Liang Shi was already in the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu was helpless, yet teased: "Teacher Liang, you're so competitive¹."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I just woke up early." Liang Shi explained: "It just rained, the air outside is super fresh."

"You went for a walk?"

"Yes."

Xu Qingzhu was amazed: "Teacher Liang, your routine is so elderly."

Liang Shi: "....."

For a moment, she didn't know if this was a compliment.

Liang Shi made congee in the morning and also asked Xu Qingzhu if, after eating such spicy food last night, her stomach felt uncomfortable.

As a result, Xu Qingzhu said she was perfectly fine and even had a good dream.

Liang Shi rubbed her somewhat uncomfortable stomach and admitted with slight difficulty: "Then I might indeed be entering the elderly ranks."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

When Xu Qingzhu finished drinking her congee and went to clear the table, she patted Liang Shi's shoulder: "Teacher Liang, exercise well."

Liang Shi: "....."

Early in the morning, Liang Shi felt like she'd been subjected to passive-aggressive remarks².

However, this also indicated from another angle that Xu Qingzhu's emotions had completely adjusted.

She finally felt a bit more at ease.

It wasn't in vain that she gave up this mission!

But fortunately, this afternoon she could complete one side mission.

And this week she could arrange to go on a trip with Xu Qingzhu to complete the second side mission.

While Liang Shi was still calculating her missions, Xu Qingzhu had already arrived at the company.

The Design Department urgently needed fresh blood, so they posted job openings.

Today was the day for second-round interviews after one round of screening.

Xu Qingzhu went directly to the Human Resources Department. There was a dedicated office for conducting recruitment.

The first round of screening had already eliminated most unqualified candidates. The second round had eight people left, from which they needed to select four to enter the Design Department—quite a high ratio.

Those who could enter the second round of interviews were all relatively outstanding, whether looking at their graduating institutions or past design works—all were quite good.

When Xu Qingzhu saw a work she couldn't make up her mind about, she called Zhou Yian over.

Zhou Yian was quite surprised. She had originally thought that after the autumn new product launch, she would become an invisible person in the entire department and had already been considering resignation.

But Xu Qingzhu very seriously asked for her opinion, having her judge this work's completion level.

Zhou Yian wasn't very serious at first, responding quite perfunctorily with a few sentences. But Xu Qingzhu summarized her opinions and wrote them in her notebook, then handed her several more pieces.

After noticing her perfunctory attitude, Xu Qingzhu spoke to her seriously and earnestly: "Designer Zhou, please bring out your professional standards. Don't make me feel that RT's rising design star is nothing more than this. Moreover, for these newcomers, this may be an interview that decides their career fate—it concerns eight people. Please be sure to be serious and then more serious."

She used the formal "you³."

Zhou Yian suddenly felt her ears heat up. From the side, she glanced at Xu Qingzhu several more times and found that she was very seriously reading the interview candidates' materials. So she also put away that casual attitude.

Among the interview candidates, Xu Qingzhu saw a familiar person. When she called out the name, her tone carried a few notes of delight: "Su Meiqi."

Hearing this name, Zhou Yian also raised her head, frowning slightly, asking Xu Qingzhu for the materials: "Give me her resume."

Xu Qingzhu handed it to her: "You know her?"

"Maybe." Zhou Yian wasn't too certain either.

But the instant Su Meiqi walked in, she was certain.

Su Meiqi first saw Xu Qingzhu: "Sister Xu?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "What a coincidence."

Su Meiqi was surprised: "It is quite a coincidence. Why are you at this company?"

Zhou Yian, who hadn't said much since arriving, suddenly spoke: "This is her family's company. What should be asked now is, why are you appearing at this company?"

Su Meiqi: ".....I'm here for an interview."

She turned her head to look, and her expression changed drastically: "Zhou.....Zhou Yian?"

"It's me." Zhou Yian twirled a pen in her hand. "Are you here to gather intelligence for your family's company?"

"No!" Su Meiqi immediately retorted, glaring at her indignantly: "I'm here to work properly."

"Then why aren't you working at your family's company?" Zhou Yian asked her.

Su Meiqi: ".....I'd be treated differently, elder sister⁴!"

Xu Qingzhu looked confused: "You two know each other?"

Zhou Yian nodded, directly revealing Su Meiqi's identity: "The heiress of Haiwei Jewelry, a chuunibyou⁵ girl who designs all sorts of strange things all day long—Su Meiqi."

Su Meiqi's eyes widened: "Elder sister, you can insult me, but you can't insult the things I design."

Zhou Yian seemed to think of something, turning her head to look at Xu Qingzhu. After thinking for a moment, she said: "She has another identity—I just don't know if you're willing to listen."

Xu Qingzhu's intuition told her this should be related to herself. She pressed her lips together: "What?"

Zhou Yian's gaze swept over her, then over Su Meiqi, saying in a low voice: "She has a famous designer aunt named Su Yao."

"Hey!" Su Meiqi gritted her teeth, wishing she could go up and hit Zhou Yian, huffing indignantly: "My aunt is at least half your teacher! And you're selling me out like this?"

Footnotes:

¹ Competitive (卷) - Internet slang derived from "involution" (内卷), referring to excessive competition or overachievement. Here used playfully to tease someone for working too hard or being overly diligent.

² Passive-aggressive remarks (陰陽怪氣) - Literally "yin-yang strange energy," a Chinese expression describing sarcastic, mocking, or passive-aggressive comments that seem polite on the surface but carry negative undertones.

³ Formal "you" (您) - In Chinese, 您 (nín) is a respectful form of "you" used to show deference or maintain professional distance, as opposed to the casual 你 (nǐ). Its use here signals Xu Qingzhu's serious, professional tone.

⁴ Elder sister (姐姐) - Used here as a term of exasperation or pleading, similar to saying "come on!" or addressing someone older/senior to you. Not indicating an actual familial relationship.

⁵ Chuunibyou (中二少女) - Literally "second-year middle school girl," a term borrowed from Japanese describing someone (typically adolescent or young adult) who acts immature, has grandiose delusions, or engages in embarrassing behavior while thinking they're cool or special. Often translated as "eighth-grader syndrome."